



SKOAR!

PlayStation Vita that really impressed. The graphical power of the handheld is nearly approaching that of the PlayStation 3 which provides for games that look absolutely outstanding. Uncharted looks especially impressive. The system is also loaded with technology, such as its multi-touch OLED display, multi-touch rear surface, motion sensors, front and rear cameras, as well as Wi-Fi and 3G connectivity. Some games will also feature full integration and cross-play with PlayStation 3. In the upcoming dungeon crawler *Ruin* you can play while on-the-go on the PS Vita and then continue when you get home on the PlayStation 3. That is reminiscent of the kind of connectivity Nintendo plans for their new console's controller, but with the Vita you get a full gaming system while on the go. Sony's pricing for the handheld system is also extremely aggressive.

Least Surprising Announcement

The least surprising announcement of E3 2011 comes by way of Microsoft in the form of the dual debut of *Halo 4* and *Halo: Combat Evolved Anniversary*. *Halo* is the star in the Xbox lineup and despite the departure of Bungie there was no way Microsoft would go more than 2 years without a new game starring the Master Chief. *Halo 4* was shown only as a teaser trailer and was billed as being the first in a new trilogy for the Xbox 360. Without Bungie behind the game it will be interesting to see what changes take place in the franchise.

A high definition remake of the original

Halo has also been long rumored and Microsoft made it official during their E3 press conference. Rather than completely redeveloping the game, it will basically be a new graphical engine running atop the original game's code. That means it will play exactly the same as the original game did, with the same gameplay balance and physics. For longtime fans of the game this was a huge relief. Many of the original *Halo*'s multiplayer maps will also be remade, but will be released separately for play with *Halo: Reach* as Microsoft doesn't seem to want to segregate their online user base.

Disappointment of the Show

Nintendo's Wii U stands out as the disappointment of the show. The new controller is an interesting take on things, housing its own screen and battery pack and despite that feeling relatively comfortable and lightweight. We actually are quite excited to see how it will be used by developers as it has the potential (if correctly utilized) to innovate gaming in much the same way the original Wii did. The unfortunate aspect is just how early in development all of it was – the whole thing came off as rushed in an effort by Nintendo to get their console in the public eye before either of their competitors do (expect PlayStation 4 and Next Xbox at next year's show).

The result of this hasty debut was a limited number of systems on the show floor, with lengthy lines required to even try the system if you were not a member of the media. The design of the console is also not finalized, with no specific announcements regarding system power, price, or appearance. Most importantly though was the complete lack of any real software to play. Nintendo had a handful of demos to showcase the type of things that could be done, but nothing was playable that resembled a real game.

Final Words

The lasting impression I came away with from this year's show was a heightened desire for control from developers. For example, 2K Games entire booth was closed off to the public. Without an appointment the only things you could see were a controlled demo of *The Darkness II* and *Duke Nukem Forever*'s multiplayer mode. Even with an appointment games like *Bioshock: Infinite* and *XCOM* were only shown in a controlled fashion with developers running through demos. No photography or video recording of any kind was allowed. At Electronic Arts it was much the same, with games like *Mass Effect 3* and *Star Wars: The Old Republic* only being shown behind closed doors in developer demos. *The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim* from Bethesda was shown in much the same way.

Developers are doing this because they realize the potentially devastating effects negative publicity can have on a game that is still very early in development. While the press at large has always had the awareness to overlook things like bugs in preview builds of games, E3 is open to the industry in general. With the proliferation of blogs and social networking anyone involved in the industry, such as someone in retail, can quickly spread negative impressions of a game. These closed door demos are the developers' way of controlling not only which specific individuals can see their games, but also exactly what they can see. They can avoid showing areas or doing things that would result in the game crashing. It is completely understandable but also frustrating for those attending the show as it goes against much of the reason E3 exists; for the industry to get an early chance to play upcoming games. Gone is the show floor filled with stations to play games, instead mostly replaced with private meeting areas. 

